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★★★★ \$5.00

DIJA Closed (42544.22)

NASDAQ Closed (19310.79)

STOXX 600 Closed (507.62)

10-YR. TREAS. Closed (yield 4.577%)

OIL Closed (\$71.72)

GOLD Closed (\$2629.20)

EURO \$1.0360

YEN 157.40

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Over the past 10 years**, the SEC has written off almost \$10 billion in penalties that it can't collect, according to data obtained by The Wall Street Journal under the Freedom of Information Act. **A1**

◆ **Hawaiian Electric** agreed to sell its community bank subsidiary to an investor group in a deal that could help the utility as it resolves a nearly \$2 billion settlement related to the 2023 Maui wildfires. **B3**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** ended Tuesday's session, the last of 2024, in the red, with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow falling 0.4%, 0.9% and less than 0.1%, respectively. **B9**

◆ **Investors' hopes** for a "Santa Claus rally"—a rise in stocks over the period that spans the last five trading days of the year through the first two of the next—have faded. **B1**

◆ **Chinese companies** commenced public offerings in Hong Kong, part of a flurry of year-end activity with investor demand for listings picking up in the Asian financial hub. **B9**

◆ **A public-relations** battle involving the stars of "It Ends With Us" escalated into a full-fledged legal brawl when actor and director Justin Baldoni and his publicists sued the New York Times for libel. **B1**

◆ **An appeals court** overturned a bankruptcy plan for mattress-maker Serta Simmons to hand control of the company to one group of lenders while excluding others. **B3**

◆ **Swedish debt collector** Intrum won U.S. court approval for a \$4.6 billion debt restructuring, defeating a bondholder group that argued the company didn't need or deserve bankruptcy protections. **B9**

World-Wide

◆ **A man in a pickup truck** flying an Islamic State flag plowed into a large crowd in New Orleans's French Quarter early New Year's Day, killing 15 people and injuring more than 30 in what authorities called a terrorist attack. **A1**

◆ **The suspect** in the attack was a born-and-bred Texan, an Army veteran, and father of three who had climbed the corporate ladder, but in recent years his life appears to have taken a darker turn. **A4**

◆ **A Tesla Cybertruck** loaded with canisters of gas and firework mortars exploded in front of the Trump hotel in Las Vegas, killing one person and injuring seven. **A4**

◆ **Russia halted** natural-gas flows to Europe via Ukraine, as Kyiv's refusal to extend a pipeline deal ended one of the last remaining energy links between Russia and what was once its biggest market. **A1**

◆ **Chief Justice John Roberts** in a year-end report said American courts are menaced by violence, intimidation, disinformation and threats to defy lawfully entered judgments. **A3**

◆ **Trump's immigration** agenda faces substantial headwinds that include hearings backlogs, personnel and materiel shortages, blue-state resistance and a lack of cooperation from foreign countries. **A5**

◆ **Chinese leader Xi Jinping** in a New Year's address sought to shore up confidence that Beijing can make an economic transition and resist foreign pressure weeks before Trump returns to the White House. **A6**

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New Orleans Attack Leaves 15 Dead



MATTHEW HINTON/AGENCY IMAGES

FBI investigators worked at the scene Wednesday where a man drove a pickup truck into a crowd of New Year's revelers in New Orleans. The driver, who was killed by police, was identified as Army veteran Shamsud-Din Jabbar, a U.S.-born citizen from Texas.

Driver displaying Islamic State flag plows into crowd; accomplices eyed

A man in a pickup truck flying an Islamic State flag plowed into a large crowd in New Orleans's French Quarter early New Year's Day, killing 15 people and injuring more than 30 in what authorities called a terrorist attack.

By Sadie Gurman, Joseph Pisani, Rachel Wolfe, Nancy A. Youssef and Laine Higgins

Two police officers also were injured in a shootout with the suspect, a U.S. Army veteran, who was killed in the exchange of fire.

The Federal Bureau of Investigation identified him as 42-year-old Shamsud-Din Jabbar, a U.S.-born citizen from Texas. The flag was attached to the trailer hitch of the rented Ford pickup, in which investigators found weapons and a potential explosive device. Investigators were working to learn more

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◆ **Suspect had money woes, messy divorce**..... A4

SEC Drops \$10 Billion In Fines From Books

By DAVE MICHAELS

Paul Bilzerian has been on the run from the Securities and Exchange Commission for so long that he now owes the agency \$180 million with interest—almost three times what a court initially ordered him to pay.

For 31 years, the agency tried and failed to collect a \$62 million judgment against the former corporate raider for securities fraud.

To avoid paying the penalty, Bilzerian pleaded poverty and twice declared bankruptcy. He later moved to the island nation of St. Kitts and Nevis, beyond the reach of the U.S. government.

The financier told The Wall Street Journal in 2014 that he "would rather starve to death than earn a dollar to feed myself and pay the government a penny of it." So far, he has mostly succeeded.

This fall, federal prosecutors charged Bilzerian, 74 years old, with new crimes they said he committed with millions of dollars he hid from the SEC. He hasn't answered the charges, and declined to comment.

The case is emblematic of the commission's long struggle to enforce its judgments against people who go to great lengths to avoid paying them. And in other circumstances,

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Russian Gas Link to Europe Stops

By GEORGI KANTCHEV AND LAURENCE NORMAN

Russia halted natural-gas flows to Europe via Ukraine, as Kyiv's refusal to extend a pipeline deal ended one of the last remaining energy links between Russia and what was once its biggest market.

A gas-transit deal using Soviet-era pipelines crisscrossing Ukraine expired at the end of 2024. Ukraine had said it wouldn't extend the deal because it was providing revenues that helped Moscow conduct its war in Ukraine. Russian gas exporter Gazprom said it halted flows in the

early hours of the new year as the deal expired.

"Due to the Ukrainian side's repeated and explicit refusal to extend these agreements, Gazprom was deprived of the technical and legal opportunity to supply gas for transit," the company said on Wednesday.

Ukraine hailed the halt to the flow of Russian gas, saying it would strike a blow against its enemy.

"This is a historical event. Russia is losing markets, it will suffer financial losses," Energy Minister German Gushchenko of Ukraine said.

The end of the deal, bro-

kered by the European Union in 2019, was long expected and will have limited impact on Europe's gas supplies—unlike earlier in the conflict when Russian gas stoppages upended European gas markets and unleashed a price surge for consumers and factories.

Europe has slashed its reliance on Russian gas. Moscow used to supply as much as 45% of the EU's imports before the war, but that share fell to 15% in 2023. Russia still exports pipeline gas to Europe via Turkey, selling to customers such as Hungary and Serbia, and it sends liquefied natural gas via ships. The Ukrainian

transit link covered about 5% of the EU's total imports.

Europe has prepared for the end of the Ukraine deal by lowering gas use and diversifying its suppliers. The EU's gas demand is 18% lower than in 2022, while storage levels reached over 95% as of Nov. 1.

Throughout the conflict, countries such as Germany rushed to build LNG terminals to receive gas from big producers, including the U.S. and Qatar. EU countries also increased deliveries from Nor-

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◆ **Ukraine advances killer robot drones**..... A7

Biden Battles for Legacy, Believing He Could Have Won

President ends term listing wins—and facing criticism on Trump

The beginning of the end of Joe Biden's political life was off to a very slow start.

The Monday speeches at the Democratic National Convention in August had run over their allotted time, delaying Biden's swan song address to delegates. Organizers rushed to speed

By Erich Schwartzel, Emily Glazer and Annie Linskey

things up. A video highlighting his 50-year career in politics was scrapped.

When the country's oldest president finally took the stage in Chicago at 10:27 p.m., the crowd erupted with chants of "We love Joe!" For 50 minutes, Biden extolled his administration's accomplishments and touted the qualifications of Vice President Kamala Harris, who

later that week would accept the nomination that once belonged to Biden.

Toward the end of the speech, Biden quoted a Gene Scheer song, "American Anthem." "The work and prayers of centuries have brought us to this day," the president recited. "What shall our legacy be?"

But Biden tripped over the key word: "legacy."

It was a fitting start to Biden's final public chapter, replete with poor timing, awkward execution and an imperfect crafting of his own legacy.

When Biden later jetted off to regroup at the 8,000-acre estate of his friend and donor Joe Kiani outside of Santa Barbara, Calif., he was already grappling with the consequences of the

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Big Leap Into the New Year



CLAUDIA GRECO/REUTERS

TAKING THE PLUNGE: A man braved the chill as he dived into the Tiber River from the Ponte Cavour on Wednesday, as part of traditional New Year's Day celebrations in Rome.

A Game on His Xbox Led to Crypto Thievery

By ROBERT MCMILLAN

Ricky Handschumacher's first step on a path that would earn him millions of dollars in stolen cryptocurrency and a run-in with the law happened during a game of Halo 3.

His Xbox screen went black for a few minutes while he was playing the futuristic first-person shooter game that pits humans against aliens. When it returned to normal, he had been killed. He was the victim of a form of videogame cheating called "standbying."

A gamer friend on his high-school baseball team told Handschumacher about an online forum where he could learn how to use this technique, which he began doing

within a few days. Just 16 at the time, he had unwittingly stumbled into a compelling and chaotic community, eventually known as the Com, that was pushing the limits of online behavior.

Over the next 15 years this group of gamers and hackers would grow up with Handschumacher, emerging as a major cybersecurity threat. They developed techniques that would wreak havoc on U.S. technology and telecommunications companies, while generating for some members millions of dollars in theft and extortion payments.

"We've seen an uptick in the severity of and the sheer number of folks who are at a

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Fewer Tips For Asia's Traffic Helpers

* * *

Indonesia's move away from cash hurts 'small people'

By STU WOO AND FADIYAH ALAIDRUS

JAKARTA, Indonesia—A hallmark of Indonesian daily life is facing extinction.

For decades, a slice of this country's 280 million people have made a buck off its infamous traffic. Men and women stand in the street and help cars make turns, in exchange for tips of a few cents handed out the window.

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